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3.1 Habit

The general form of a plant is referred to as habit. Based on habit plants are classified into herbs, shrubs, climbers (vines) and trees.

I. Herbs

Herbs are soft stemmed plants with less wood or no wood. According to the duration of their life they may be classified as **annuals**, **biennials** and **perennials**. Perennial herbs having a bulb, corm, rhizome or tuber as the underground stem are termed as **geophytes.** Example: *Phyllanthus amarus, Cleome viscosa.*

II. Shrubs

A shrub is a perennial, woody plant with several main stems arising from the ground level. Example: *Hibiscus*

III. Climbers (Vine)

An elongated weak stem generally supported by means of climbing devices are called **Climbers** (vines) which may be annual or perennial, herbaceous or woody.

Liana is a vine that is perennial and woody. Liana's are major components in the tree canopy layer of some tropical forests. Example: *Ventilago, Entada*, *Bougainvillea.*

IV. Trees

A tree is a stout, tall, perennial, woody plant having one main stem called **trunk** with many lateral branches. Example: mango, sapota, jack, fig, teak. If the trunk remains unbranched it is said to be **caudex.** Example: Palmyra, coconut.

3.2 Plant habitat

Depending upon where plants grow habitats may be classified into major categories: I. Terrestrial and II.Aquatic.

I. Terrestrial

Plants growing on land are called **terrestrial plants.** The following table illustrate the types of terrestrial plants classified based on their environmental adaptation.

II. Aquatic

Plants that are living in water environment are called **aquatic plants** or hydrophytes.

3.3 Life Span

Based on life span plants are classified into 3 types. They are annual, biennial and perennial

Terrestrial habitat		
Types	**Nature of environmental adaptation**	**Example**
Mesophytes	Growing in soils with sufficient water	*Azadirachta indica*
Xerophytes	Growing on dry habitats	*Opuntia*, *Euphorbia*
Psammophytes	Growing on sand	*Ipomoea pes-caprae*, *Spinifex littoralis*
Lithophytes	Growing on rock	Many algae and lichens, *Ficus spp*